

Journey Through Grief

- Acknowledge the reality of the death
- Embrace the pain of the loss
- Remember the person who died
- Develop a new self-identity
- Search for meaning
- Receive ongoing support from others

Healing Feelings: Traumatic Grief and Beyond

A Process Model of Recovery in the Aftermath of Death and Loss

Managing stress involves honoring the grief process, whether it be positive or negative. All of us, no matter what our job or background, will experience stress or grief, whether it's the loss of a job, or relationship, a loss of hope, a financial crisis, or the death of a loved one. That's a fact and it can feel out of control. The good news is that we can take back our power and get the help we deserve.

The Center for Living With Dying has created four steps to stress management— acknowledge, express, act, and celebrate— to build the 'new normal.'

Acknowledge what has happened to you and your reactions.

It is a reflection of the depth of your love and caring. Don't minimize or negate your grief.

The first step is to accept that you are a normal person living through an abnormally painful time. You are entitled to your feelings.

Steps to Acknowledge

- List your fears
- Focus on what is most difficult to handle RIGHT NOW
- What do you need to do to help the situation RIGHT NOW

Express your feelings and issues.

By expressing yourself, you are bringing your feelings from inside the body to the outside. You are making what you feel into something tangible— either visually or verbally.

Ways to Express

- Letter Writing— make it uncensored, only you will see it
- Talk— see a nonjudgmental support person
- Exercise

Act

Create as much meaning and ceremony as you can to bring closure to the event of loss. Do something active that will acknowledge your pain and help you transform it into the remembering of the love. Normalize the rest of your life as much as possible. Do not change too much at one time. If there are other life changes you have no control over, acknowledge them. Realize that you only have to deal with the most pressing issue right now.

Tips on Action Steps

- Do specific concrete actions to facilitate the changes you are experiencing
- Bring closure in the company of friends and family
- Do something playful, fun, relaxing

Celebrate

Give yourself the opportunity to acknowledge your victories. Look back at what you have survived and accomplished. Do something fun and life affirming which rewards you for a job well done.

